THE NDA CHOICE

- **A Tamil Gounder (OBC) and two-time Coimbatore MP, C.P. Radhakrishnan strengthens the BJP's long game to expand its presence in Tamil Nadu**
- **In him, BJP gets a dependable presiding officer in the Rajya Sabha, where several legislative battles still loom**
- **A former RSS Prant Sanghchalak, he is a symbol of the Sangh's growing convergence with constitutional power**

of the electoral college, Radhakrishnan will become the first former RSS office-bearer to occupy a constitutional office of such stature, underscoring how the Sangh's parallel hierarchy is steadily converging with that of the Indian state.

The shortlist reportedly had another contender: Karnataka governor Thawar Chand Gehlot, a prominent Dalit face from Madhya Pradesh. Geography tipped the balance. For decades, the BJP has struggled to break into the south beyond Karnataka. Modi has invested considerable capital in outreach to Tamil Nadu and Kerala, reorganising state units and stitching alliances. Elevating a Tamil leader with unimpeachable RSS credentials—less than a year before the state election—comes as a safe experiment in a laboratory on the frontier of saffron politics.

OPPOSITION NOMINEE JUSTICE B.S. REDDY EMBODIES INSTITUTIONAL INDEPENDENCE AT A MOMENT WHEN PARLIAMENT IS ACCUSED OF BEING STEAMROLLED BY BRUTE MAJORITY

Radhakrishnan also offers personal reassurance to Modi, having earned his trust standing by him through his difficult post-2002 years in Gujarat. Within the RSS, he's respected as a disciplined organiser. Caste arithmetic plays a role too. From the Gounder community, a dominant OBC caste in western Tamil Nadu, his candidature helps the BJP re-enter a social coalition it once attempted through the younger K. Annamalai and later through an alliance with the Edappadi K. Palaniswami-led AIADMK.

OPPOSITION'S SYMBOLISM

If the BJP's pick projects consolidation, the Opposition's response is heavy on symbolism. The numbers are stacked against them. The electoral college comprises all sitting MPs. Of 782 electors across both Houses, the winning mark is 392. The NDA controls about 425 votes, extending to 436 with YSR Congress support—well above the threshold. The INDIA bloc, even after counting Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs, musters only 310. Even if all other non-aligned parties rallied, they would still fall short. The Opposition knows it cannot win. Its bet is on narrative.

Justice B. Sudershan Reddy (retd), the Opposition's choice, is a former Supreme Court judge from Telangana. Not a career politician, he ticks several boxes: a southern face from a state where the Congress has recently revived itself, a senior jurist at a time when the government is accused of bending institutions, and a professional outsider whose personal stature is meant to contrast with the BJP's ideological insider.

Modi, however, thrives on such juxtapositions. In 2017, he elevated Ram Nath Kovind, a northern Dalit figure, to the post of President, and M. Venkaiah Naidu, a senior leader from the south, as VP. In 2022, he chose Droupadi Murmu, a tribal leader from Odisha, and the recent departee Jagdeep Dhankhar, a Jat face from Rajasthan. Each choice blended caste, region and ideology. Radhakrishnan reprises that same template: south, Sangh, loyalty.

His rise signals to RSS swayamsevaks that long years in the trenches matter. Naidu had been an office-bearer of the Sangh affiliate ABVP before he joined the BJP and eventually rose to the VP's post. On the other hand, the late Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, who was VP from 2002 to 2007, had been a swayamsevak, but never a senior RSS office-bearer like Radhakrishnan. This signals to Nagpur that it carries weight in Delhi's statecraft.

For the Opposition, the unity test is as crucial as the contest itself. In 2022, the TMC had abstained, citing lack of consultation. This time, it has agreed to back Reddy—that he is not a Congressman doubtless helped. Still, fault lines remain. For instance, Maharashtra's fractured politics leaves room for last-minute surprises. BJP strategists quietly hope regional compulsions might nudge Sharad Pawar's NCP (SP) and Uddhav Thackeray's Shiv Sena (UBT) at least towards abstention.

THE LARGER PLAY

The broader story goes beyond the inevitable result. First, it underscores how the south is emerging as the next big theatre of national politics. For the BJP, installing a Tamil RSS veteran in high office is part of a long game to normalise saffron leadership in Tamil Nadu. For the Congress, fielding a Telangana jurist is an attempt to deepen credibility among southern voters, especially minorities, intellectuals and professionals disillusioned with the BJP's majoritarian tilt. Justice Reddy's most noted ruling came in 2011, when he struck down the state-backed Salwa Judum militia in Chhattisgarh as unconstitutional. The BJP is citing that verdict to portray him as soft on Naxalism, an outlook it frames as the antithesis of the RSS's nationalist ideology.

Also, the VP primarily presides over the Rajya Sabha, where the BJP lacks a comfortable majority. In Radhakrishnan, Modi will have a trusted monitor. The Opposition, even in defeat, ensures the alternative vision—of institutional detachment—remains etched as principle. On September 9, when MPs line up to vote, the outcome will be clear before counting. But it's the symbolism that remains vital. ■